

MANY LANDS OF GOLD

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Many Lands of Gold

Gaily bedight,
A gallant knight,
In sunshine and in shadow,
Had journeyed long,
Singing a song,
In search of Eldorado.

But he grew old—
This knight so bold—
And o'er his heart a shadow
Fell as he found
No spot of ground
That looked like Eldorado.

And, as his strength
Failed him at length,
He met a pilgrim shadow—
'Shadow,' said he,
'Where can it be—
This land of Eldorado?'

'Over the Mountains
Of the Moon,
Down the Valley of the Shadow,
Ride, boldly ride,'
The shade replied—
'If you seek for Eldorado!

'Eldorado' (1849) by Edgar Allan Poe

Abstract

A complex intertextual nexus starts with Suvarṇabhūmi. At first we see it from afar, across the Bay of Bengal—in mythology, literature, and legend through the *longue durée*. It is futile for me to attempt to rehash the century's worth of hypotheses that have sprung up like hydra heads, then fallen redundant to the ground, only to revive yet again—for me to pretend to entertain or to reject, refute, revise, or refine them. Early savants led the way through the seas of churn. The most erudite and intellectually stimulating treatments of the literary and archaeological evidences are the masterworks of Paul Wheatley (1921–1999), *Nāgara and Commandery*

(1983) and the earlier *Golden Khersonese* (1961). So far these have not been surpassed, but Suvarṇabhūmi remains a riddle, an intellectual challenge. In this paper, I present four sites which, according to contemporary inscriptions or manuscripts, locate themselves in Suvarṇabhūmi. This leads to, or reinforces, the hypothesis that Suvarṇabhūmi refers to the region of Southeast Asia and not to any specific country, city-state, or political centre. The region of the evidence extends from lower Burma through central and peninsular Siam to Sumatra and belongs to the eleventh to the thirteenth to the fifteenth centuries.

Once upon a time there was a legendary land that was celebrated for its riches, a Suvarṇabhūmi or ‘Land of Gold’ where opportunity beckoned. When was this? Mention of the Land of Gold in Indian texts begins well before the Christian Era. We know this fabled land from a South Asian perspective, which tells us that the voyage from India was arduous and perilous, fraught with the risk of storm and shipwreck, the terror of pirates, sea monsters, and dreadful demons. But none of the texts tell us just *where* this Suvarṇabhūmi is, and the ship of geographical knowledge is left floundering. In the Sargasso sea of modern scholarship, Suvarṇabhūmi has bobbed up and down on the waves of theory and fashion, with no safe harbour or landing place in sight.

What, I wonder, can I write about Suvarṇabhūmi that has not already been written? Do I not run the risk of merely parroting those who have parroted others, of stuffing my readers’ heads with authorities built on authorities, with quotations quoted from quotations?¹ Do we have any new information that warrants venturing into the heaving seas and hazardous straits of antiquity in quest, yet again, of El Dorado, the Golden Land? If I stick within my bailiwick and restrict myself to textual studies, to inscriptions and literature, I can say frankly that no, there is no new written evidence that resolves the questions, ‘Where and what was Suvarṇabhūmi?’² But the material record, the testimonies of archaeology and early technology, has changed. Suvarṇabhūmi has spoken up. New discoveries and studies—of early manufacturing and trading sites like Khao Sam Kaew (เขาสามแก้ว), Phu Khao Thong (ภูเขาทอง), and

others old and new in peninsular Thailand, of Sungai Batu (สุโขทัย) in peninsular Malaysia (one and the same peninsula, course), of the manufacture and dissemination of beads, glass technology, and bronze drums—have changed the picture. Taken together, the new finds call for a new map and a new image of early Southeast Asia as a dynamic hub in early Asian cultural, technological, and economic history from before the Christian era. Gracefully designed bronze bowls incised with humans and animals take us back 2000 years and evoke Śunga idioms of ancient north India. Stunning golden earrings take us back to the same period; a Mauryan ringstone carries us even further back in time. Coins and inscribed objects, even if only the flotsam and jetsam of early international trade, point to a world of transcultural exchange. New finds like those presented in this volume continue to astonish. With this burgeoning material evidence in mind, perhaps it is allowable to take a new look at the narrative and poetry of the literary record.

In an earlier draft of this essay, I wrote that, ‘There are no early inscriptions in Pali or in Sanskrit, in old Mon or in old Khmer, that evoke Suvarṇabhūmi in any way’. But Sarasvatī—Goddess of Science and Arts, and Lady Luck betimes—is both capricious and compassionate, and I can now add an important exception. This is a stone slab engraved in Sanskrit in the ‘pre-Angkorian’ script that is said to bear a date equivalent to 633 CE (fig. 1). Reported to have been found by villagers twenty years ago in Baset District, Kompong Speu province, south of Phnom Penh, it is now kept in the grounds of the Kiri Sdachkong pagoda. It seems that the slab lay quiet for two decades, until 5 January, 2018, when the *Phnom Penh Post* ran an article under the headline, ‘Was Cambodia home to Asia’s ancient “Land of Gold”?’ The article states that, according to Prof. Vong Sotheara of the Royal University of Phnom Penh, the inscription refers to a king named Iśānavarman (อิศานวรมัน) ruling over, or in, Suvarṇabhūmi. We can indeed see the word *Suvarṇabhūm-xx* in line 7 (fig. 2).³ No estampages, readings, or studies of the inscription have been so far published, and for the time being it is impossible to assess its historical value and its bearing on the study of early Khmer history and

1 To paraphrase William Hazlitt, ‘On the Ignorance of the Learned’, from W.E. Williams, *A Book of English Essays*, Penguin Books, London, [1951] 1987, p. 151.

2 A classic inventory of literary and epigraphic sources is that given by R.C. Majumdar in his *Suvarṇadvīpa: Ancient Indian Colonies in the Far East* (2 vols., first published at Calcutta, 1937–38; repr. Gian Publishing House, Delhi, 1986), especially Book I, Chap. IV. Kernial Singh Sandhu, in his *Early Malaysia: Some observations on the nature of Indian contacts with pre-British Malaya* (University Education Press, Singapore, 1973), pp. 76–86, gives a useful Appendix on ‘Indian Records relating to Malaya and the rest of Southeast Asia prior to AD 1500’. For a more recent study of this question, with analysis of earlier research, see Prapod Assavavirulhakarn, *The Ascendancy of Theravāda Buddhism in Southeast Asia*, Silksworm Books, Chiang Mai, 2010, especially Chap. 3. The bibliography of Suvarṇabhūmi is vast and it is not my intention to attempt regurgitate it here.

3 Sanskrit is an inflected language, and the case ending is not clear in the photo (blown up on the computer from the newspaper photograph).



Fig 1 Inscription from Baset district, Kampong Speu province, Cambodia. After *Phnom Penh Post*, 5 January, 2018.

Fig 2 Inscription from Baset district, Kampong Speu: detail reading 'suvarṇabhūm-xx'



Suvarṇabhūmi. We must wait until the record is reliably documented.

What, I wonder, can I say, writing a thousand years and more after the age when Suvarṇabhūmi thrilled the South Asian imagination? I do not see much point in rummaging through the almirahs of dusty references—the Pali *Niddesa* and Lankan chronicles, and so on. That would be tedious. When we take the many languages of polyglot Asia into account—not only the Indian languages of Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, and Tamil, but also Tibetan, Chinese, Arabic, and Persian—references to the Land of Gold are multiple, but only a precious few, if any, are first-hand.⁴ Suvarṇabhūmi was a continent seen and dreamed from India, beckoning from the winding coasts of Southeast Asia as a destination and as a setting for adventure and romance. Sandhu's map (fig.3) showing Suvarṇabhūmi writ large may well reflect the

situation. It is my supposition that the many *dvīpas* and kingdoms of ancient Southeast Asia were located *in* Suvarṇabhūmi, but none of them *was* Suvarṇabhūmi.

Unlike Poe's Eldorado, our Suvarṇabhūmi is not 'over the Mountains of the Moon' or 'down the Valley of the Shadow', and we need not boldly ride to find it. We need to think, to think boldly; to weigh the evidence, and ask what kind of evidence we are looking for. We need to reflect on the role of ambiguity in historical research and the relative value of the notions of 'myth' and 'reality'. Are the two incompatible? Does the one cancel out the other? Suvarṇabhūmi has lived in the imagination for over two thousand years. What sort of thing are we looking for? What sort of certainties will satisfy our perennial curiosity? Or is the Land of Gold naught but a chimera?

What does Suvarṇabhūmi mean? *Suvarṇa* means gold and *bhūmi* means land, country, earth. This seems straightforward enough, but the Sanskrit compound can be interpreted in several ways. Suvarṇabhūmi can *literally* be a land where gold deposits and gold ore are plentiful; or it can

4 My own earlier contributions are Peter Skilling, 'Two Ports of Suvarṇabhūmi: A brief Note', *Journal of the Siam Society* 80.1 (1992), p. 131, and 'Dharmakīrti's *Durbodhāloka* and the Literature of Śrīvijaya', *Journal of the Siam Society* 85 (1997), pp. 187–194.

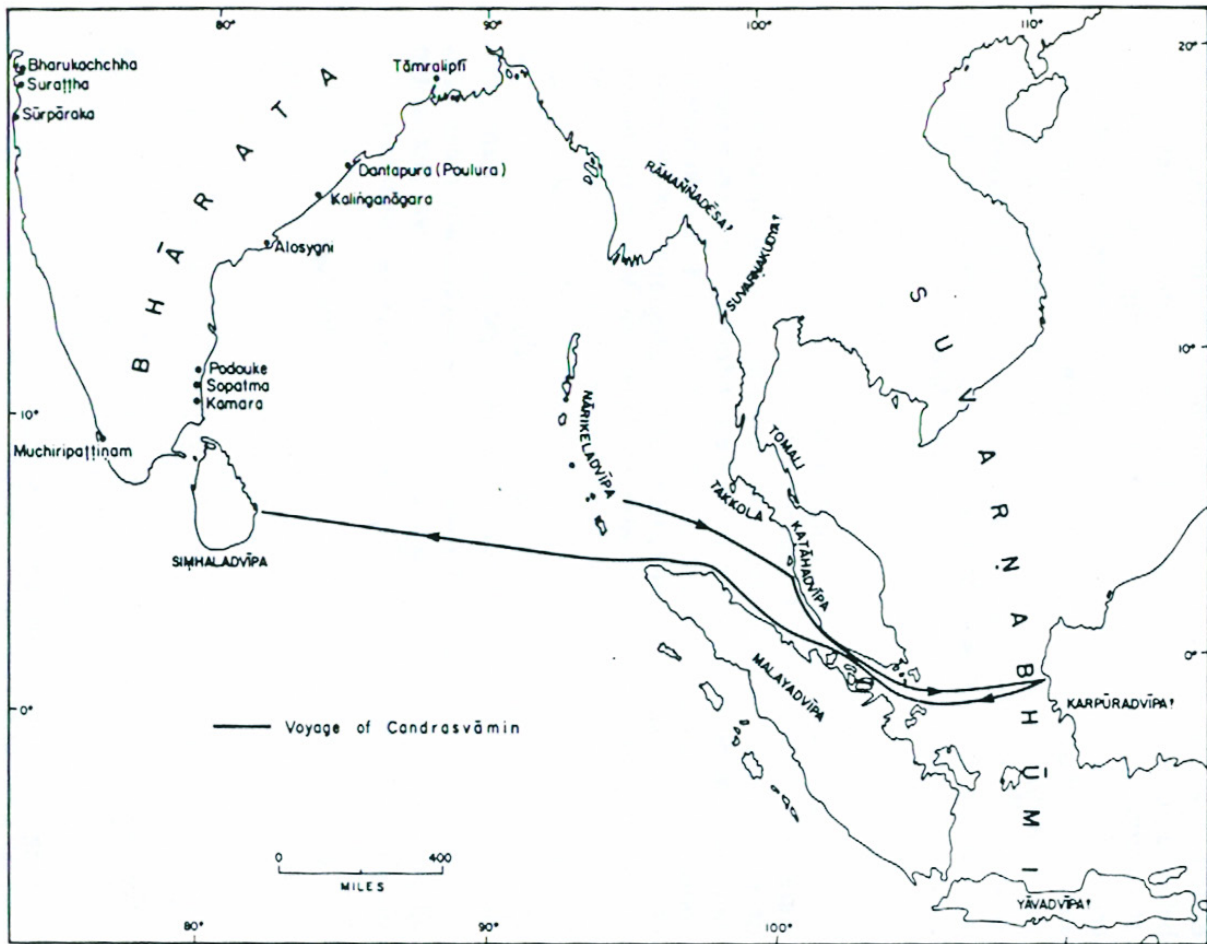


Fig 3 Suvarṇabhūmi: The Land of Gold. After Kernial Singh Sandhu, *Early Malaysia*, fig. 1.

metaphorically be a source of riches and wealth, a golden earth, prosperous and plentiful. And so on. In Indian narrative literature, Suvarṇabhūmi is a fabulous destination, a long voyage by sea from India—often from Bhārūkaccha (modern Broach or Bharuch at the mouth of the Narmada river in Gujarat on the west coast of India), or from Tāmralipti on the Bay of Bengal—and despite the dangers, merchants set out to seek their fortunes there, to get rich. Suvarṇabhūmi is covered with thick forest—and is a place of romance and adventure. Our narrators do not tell us much more than that.

And what about Suvarṇadvīpa? *Suvarṇa* means gold and *dvīpa* means island, peninsula, landmass, continent. The term *dvīpa* is widely used in ancient Indian cosmography and geography: from Jambudvīpa, the grand Indian subcontinent, to Candradvīpa, a tiny island at the mouth of the Ganga River and a place of pilgrimage since ancient times. A *dvīpa* can be anything in between these two, and the literature teems with them, from Śakadvīpa, the lands of the Iranian peoples, to Karpūradvīpa, Yavadvīpa, Malayadvīpa, Nārikeladvīpa, and to

Siṃhaladvīpa or Laṅkādvīpa, the Isle of Tabropane or Sri Lanka.⁵ One of the great entrepôts of antiquity was Kaṭāhadvīpa, today's Kedah in Malaysia, a centre of iron production since about 500 BCE. Rather than just island or peninsula, a primary meaning of *dvīpa* must have been estuary, a place accessible by water, with the adjacent coasts.

Somadeva's 'Ocean [Where Gather the] Streams of Stories' (*Kaṭhāsaritsāgara*) is just that—a collection that brims with tales, written in eleventh century Kashmir. In one tale, a merchant sets out for Suvarṇadvīpa by sea and is shipwrecked. He gains the shore and proceeds on foot to Kalaśapura.⁶ Evidence—which includes a long but fragmentary and difficult Sanskrit inscription—increasingly suggests that Kalaśapura is in the deltas of lower

5 I will give more examples below.

6 Somadeva, *Océan des rivières de contes*, édition publiée sous la direction de Nalini Balbir avec la collaboration de Mildrède Besnard, Lucien Billoux, Sylvain Brocquet, Colette Caillat, Christine Chojnacki, Jean Fezas et Jean-Pierre Osier, Bibliothèque de la Pléiade, Gallimard, Paris, 1997, p. 600 (*tarāṅga* 54, vv. 97 seq.).

Burma, in the area of the ancient city or state of Śrīkṣetra.⁷ Somadeva was a court poet in mountainous Kashmir: what were his sources for the geography of the Bay of Bengal and Southeast Asia? These are stories and not histories. The names are poetic and metaphorical: the merchant is named Samudraśūra, ‘hero of the ocean’, and he comes from Harṣapura, ‘city of joy’, but the settings are places known to the audience or readers. Even if Somadeva’s source is Guṇāḍhya’s *Bṛhat-kathā*, a celebrated anthology of stories composed in Prakrit in the first half of the first millennium, that work is long lost and cannot help us. Beyond Suvarṇadvīpa, there are other toponyms that evoke the glory of gold: Suvarṇakūḍya, Suvarṇapura, and Kāñcanapura. In fiction and in statecraft, gold meant glory and prestige.

Suvarṇabhūmi has two main literary sources, and it is important to distinguish them as we examine the question. One is ancient Indian geographical lore, mostly as expressed in narratives and adventures as well as in a few historical records. Another is the Theravādin chronicles written in the Pali language in Sri Lanka; these tell a particular story about how, after the third recitation convocation of that tradition, two monks, Sona and Uttara by name, were sent to Suvarṇabhūmi to propagate the Dharma. This gives Suvarṇabhūmi a special relationship with Buddhism. Suvarṇabhūmi is mentioned in the ancient ‘canonical’ Pali commentary, the *Niddesa*; in post-canonical Pali literature we find it in the *Milindapañha*, the commentaries, and the Lankan chronicles *Dīpavaṃsa* and *Mahāvāṃsa*. Even if there is no evidence for Sona and Uttara’s mission to Suvarṇabhūmi during the Aśokan period, there is no evidence against it. The recent material evidence for the early technical and cultural development of Southeast Asia, especially the Thai-Malay peninsula, supports not the *historicity* of the mission or the introduction of Buddhism in the Aśokan era, but the *potentiality* or *possibility* of the establishment of Buddhist centres before the Christian era. We know that by this

period, Buddhist monastics and Buddhist merchants travelled widely, and we know that trade and technological exchanges flourished.

The idea is further supported by the fact that when the archaeological curtain lifts, the stage is already set. Buddhism—and Brahmanism—have already arrived and are well settled in by the sixth or seventh centuries. The complex of states that we conventionally call Dvāravatī had developed an elegant writing system based on South Indian Brahmi; they used Pali for Dharma citation inscriptions, Sanskrit for royal and other records, and Mon to record local acts of merit. This presence of Pali is something special and unique. Ancient Pali inscriptions are found in only two areas, which I call ‘Pali epigraphic zones’. Both zones are in Southeast Asia, in the region once known as Suvaṇṇabhūmi/Suvarṇabhūmi/Suvarṇadvīpa. One, the ‘Śrīkṣetra zone’, is the Irrawaddy river valley and delta in lower Burma. The other, the ‘Dvāravatī zone’, is the Chao Phraya valley in lower Siam. In both areas, Pali verses and teaching formulas are engraved on stone and on metal. The Malay peninsula belongs, on the other hand, to a Sanskrit epigraphic zone. Evidence of Buddhism is found in Sanskrit inscriptions, including the *ye dharmā* stanza, the *ajñānāc-cīyate karma* verse,⁸ and two or three verses from the Mahāyānist *Sāgarāmati-paripṛcchā*.⁹ Beyond this there are stone and metal images and clay tablets of Buddhas and bodhisatvas.

It seems safe to identify the Sanskrit Kaṭāha or Kaṭāhadvīpa with modern Kedah in Northwestern Malaysia on the Straits of Malacca, the grand sea route between India and China. In his ‘Garland of Birth Stories’ (*Jātaka-mālā*), the celebrated fourth-century Indian poet Āryaśūra recounts the *Supārāga-jātaka*. A shipload of merchants sets out for Suvarṇabhūmi from Bhārukaccha on the west

7 P. Skilling, ‘The Geography of Pali and Ānanda Ācariya’, paper presented at the conference ‘From Vijayapuri to Śrīkṣetra? The beginnings of Buddhist exchange across the Bay of Bengal’, Pondichery, 31 July–4 August, 2017. It is included as Kalaśavarapura among the holy sites in the illuminated *Perfection of Wisdom* manuscripts discussed below.

8 Peter Skilling, ‘An Untraced Buddhist Verse Inscription from (Pen)insular Southeast Asia,’ in D. Christian Lam-merts (ed.), *Buddhist Dynamics in Premodern and Early Modern Southeast Asia*, Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore, 2015, pp. 18–79.

9 Peter Skilling, ‘*Sāgarāmati-paripṛcchā* Inscriptions from Kedah, Malaysia’, in *Reading Slowly: A Festschrift for Jens E. Braarvig*, edited by Lutz Edzard, Jens. W. Borgland, and Ute Hüsken, Harrassowitz Verlag, Wiesbaden, 2018, pp. 433–460.

coast of India. A terrible storm arises, and the ship is ‘driven far off from both ports’. What are these two ports? The poet does not tell us. A Sanskrit commentary composed by an unknown author ‘no earlier than AD 700’ states that the ‘two ports of Suvarṇabhūmi are Laṅkāśobha and Kaṭāhadvīpa.’¹⁰ If Laṅkāśobha refers to Lankasuka, the region of Pattani on the eastern coast of the peninsula, then this defines Kaṭāha as having ports on both coasts, east and west, and shows that the commentator is aware of the trans-peninsular route. The route would have given Kaṭāha a marked advantage in the Southeast Asian trade system.

Suvarṇabhūmi was a wide region of coasts, mountain ranges, valleys, and winding rivers, estuaries, islands and islets. Sparsely populated, it is never clearly defined in ancient sources. Within it, many states arose, flourished, and ran their courses. It is only in later periods that we get wider surveys of the Southeast Asian map. When Mpu Prapañca wrote his old Javanese *Deśavarṇana* or *Nāgarakṛtāgama* in the second half of the fourteenth century, he reveals the state of knowledge of the places ‘under the protection of the king’ of Majapahit, and of neighbouring states with which the king enjoyed, or wished to enjoy, good relations.¹¹

Syangka, Ayodhyapura, not to mention
Dharmanagari,
Marutama and Rājapura and especially
Singhanagari
Campa, Kamboja and Yawana are always
friends.

The regional powers are forming, and the

¹⁰ Peter Khoroché (tr.), *Once the Buddha Was a Monkey: Ārya Śūra's Jātakamālā*, The University of Chicago Press, 1989, p. 99 and p. 263, n. 6, *suvarṇabhūmipattanadvayam laṅkāśobhaḥ kaṭāhadvīpaḥ ca*. Khoroché suggest that ‘the two ports in question are perhaps the port of departure, Bhārukaccha, and the port of destination in Suvarṇabhūmi’. Even if this is the poet’s intent, the *Ṭikā* shows the commentator’s knowledge of two peninsular ports linking up to a trans-shipment route. For a note on the *Ṭikā*, see Peter Khoroché, ‘Jātakamālāṭīkā’, *South Asian Studies* Vol. 1 (1985), pp. 63–66. See further Skilling ‘Two Ports of Suvarṇabhūmi: A brief note’.

¹¹ *Deśavarṇana (Nāgarakṛtāgama)* by Mpu Prapañca, translated by Stuart Robson, KITLV Press, Leiden, 1995, Canto 15.1, p. 34.

trans-peninsular sites have taken on local definition. We can recognize many of the names right away. The following passage names four Malay principalities that straddle the Thai-Malay peninsula—known in their Thai forms as Lankasuka, Saiburi, Kelantan, and Trengannu—and the last line mentions Kedah.¹²

In the territory of Pahang the main places are
Hujing and Medini,
Lengkasuka and Sai as well as Kalanten and
Tringgano,
Naṣor, Paka, Muwar, Ḍungun, Tumasik and
Sang Hyang Hujung,
Kelang, Keda, Jere, Kañjap and Niran, the
whole region as a group.

The first millennium went by without leaving any evidence that Southeast Asians *themselves* identified with Suvarṇabhūmi. The evidence is Indian. In the second millennium, the configurations of Asian and world power changed, and the maps of Southeast Asia changed accordingly, as a result of both internal and external dynamics. We tend to see borders as solid, to take them for granted, as if they were natural divisions rather than arbitrary lines upon the earth. We do not remember that they are delineations of power, that many of them are by-products of colonial formations. In Southeast Asia, we usually see states as vertical alignments ranged side by side with their capitals lying in the deltas of the great North-South rivers. But earlier on there was a cultural continuum, a Buddhist continuum, that ran East and West, and is mapped by the sacred sites, the *cetiya*s, of the twelve *nakṣatra* นักษัตร of northern Siam (Lanna ล้านนา). (see map, fig. 4) These connected Buddha Gaya, the seat of awakening in Magadha in India, to Kyaiktiyo in lower Burma, to a network of sites in northern Siam and to Nakhon Phanom (นครพนม) on the Mekong River. Buddhism was transregional, the sangha was interactive; ideas were not compartmentalized but part of a dynamic pool or stream. The quest to localize Suvarṇabhūmi as a single static site or nation state goes against the logic of history.

¹² *Deśavarṇana* Canto 14.2, p. 34.

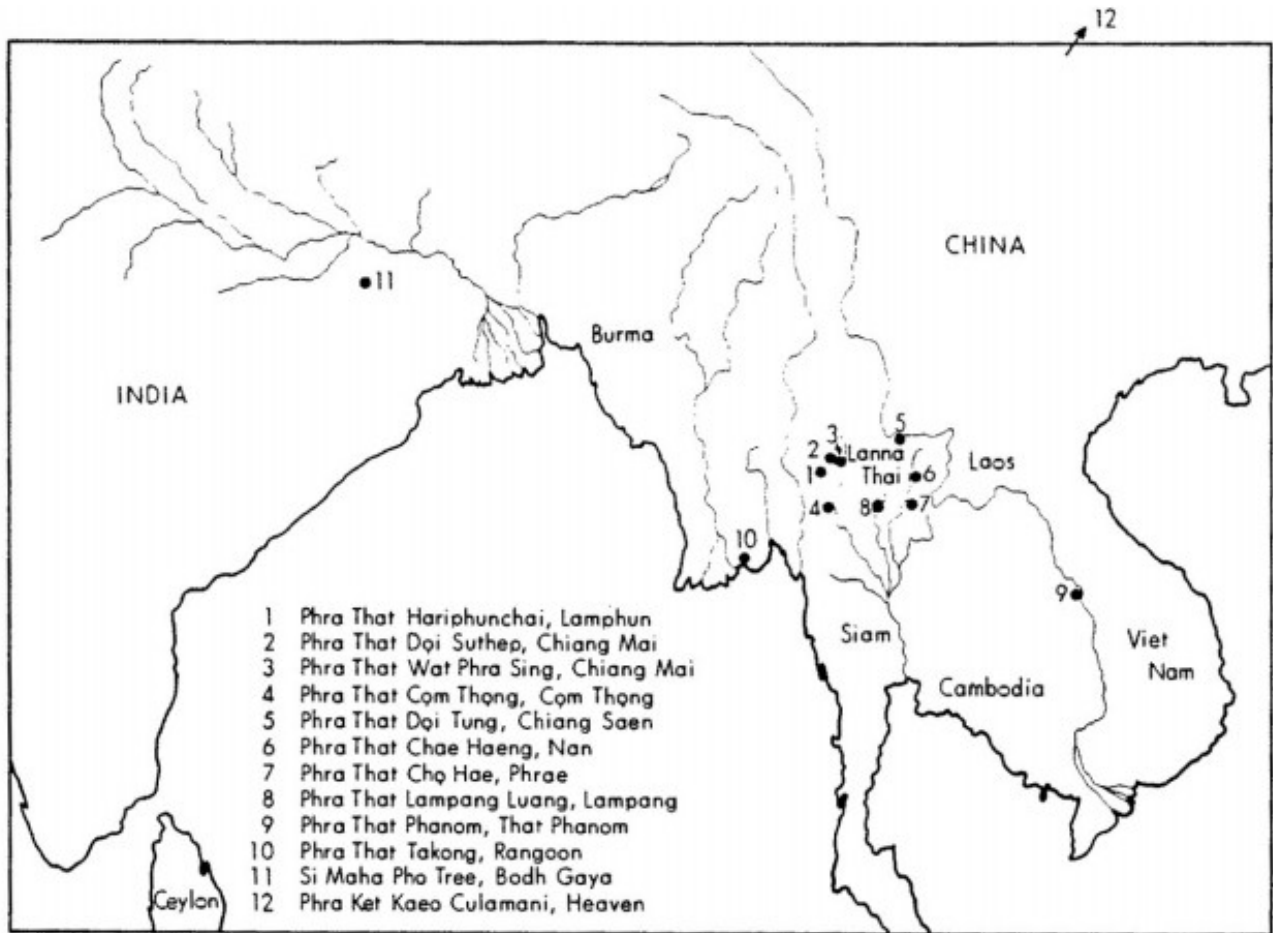


Fig 4 Map of the twelve *caityas* or places of pilgrimage according to the northern Thai tradition. After Charles Keyes, 'Buddhist Pilgrimage Centers and the Twelve-year Cycle: Northern Thai Moral Orders in Space and Time', *History of Religion* 18(1) (1975).

Suvarṇabhūmi in central Siam

The early and pre-modern geographical conceptions of Siam have received insufficient study. The *Jinakālamālīnī*, a Pali work composed in Chiang Mai by Ratanapañña Thera in 1518 CE (with additions up to 1528), places the Thai Kingdom of Sukhothai in Siam in southeastern Jambudīpa: 'a king named Roca was reigning in the city of Sukhodaya in the Syāma Country which is situated in the fringe of the south-eastern sector of Jambudīpa'.¹³ That is, the greater frame for the author

of the *Jinakālamālīnī* was Jambudīpa.¹⁴ What about Suvarṇabhūmi? By the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, two early Thai language inscriptions refer to the Golden Land and spell it in very much the same way, as a hybrid Thai-Indic loanword conforming to Thai pronunciation rules. Both of them locate Suvarṇabhūmi firmly in central Thailand, in the province now known as Suphanburi (Subarṇapuri สุพรรณบุรี). These are the inscription of King Ramkhamhaeng พ่อขุนรามคำแหง of Sukhothai สู่โขทัย and a gold foil inscription, 'Wat Song Khob 1' from Wat Song Khob วัดสองกบ in Chainat ชัยนาท.

13 N.A. Jayawickrama, tr., *The Sheaf of Garlands of the Epochs of the Conqueror, being a translation of Jinakālamālipakaraṇaṃ of Ratanapañña Thera of Thailand*, The Pali Text Society, London, [1968] 1978, p. 121; *Jinakālamālī*, transcribed from a Siamese text and edited by Aggamahāpandita A.P. Buddhaddatta, The Pali Text Society, London, 1962, p. 87.15, *jambudīpe pubba-dakkhiṇa-dīśantarāle syāmadese eko rocarājā nāma sukho-dayapure rājjaṃ kāresi*. I follow the tradition that the title is *Jinakālamālīnī*.

14 The meaning and extent of Jambudvīpa can be ambiguous. It can be South and Southeast Asia writ large, as in the *Jinakālamālīnī*, or it can be the continent of India—for example in the Pali chronicles of Sri Lanka, in which the island of Lanka is presented as outside of Jambudīpa (the Pali form), which is the Indian subcontinent properly speaking: people can come from Jambudīpa to the island or go from the island to Jambudīpa.

Face 4

1. Inverted Rubbing

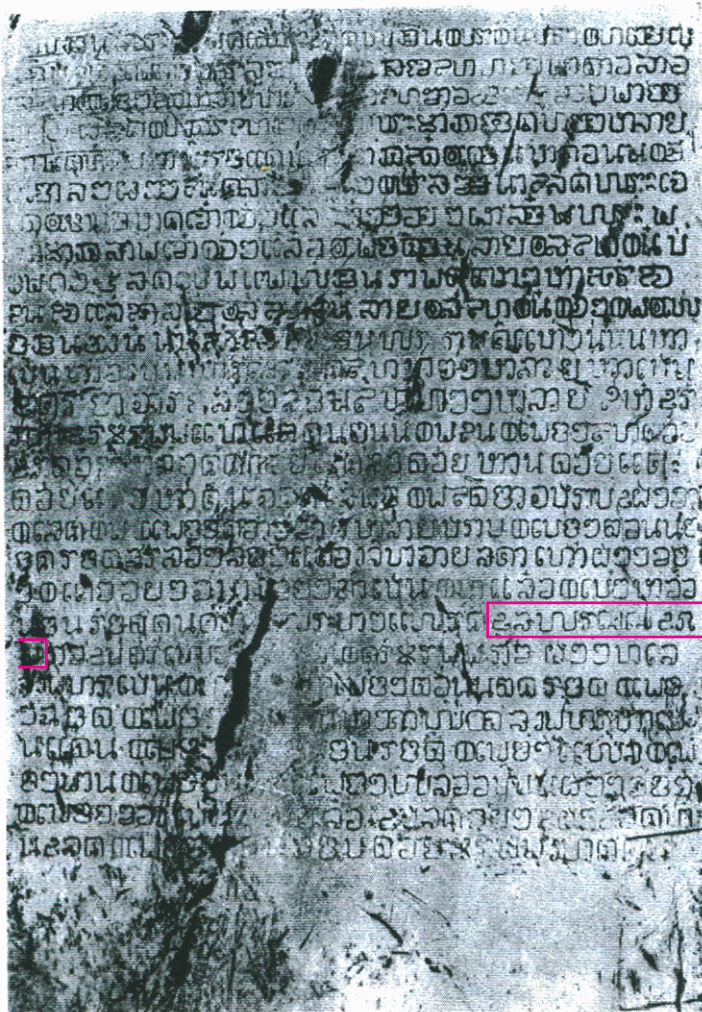


Fig 8 Inscription no 1, face 4, estampage, with Suvannabhūmi highlighted (line 20–21). After Terwiel, *The Ram Khamhaeng Inscription*, p. 68.

Face 4

2. Transcription

១ បំណងហ្មត្រាវេន្យាវត្តនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៣ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៤ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៥ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៦ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៧ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៨ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ៩ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១០ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១១ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១២ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៣ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៤ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៥ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៦ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៧ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៨ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ១៩ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២០ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២១ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២២ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២៣ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២៤ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២៥ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២៦ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ
 ២៧ ឈ្មោះនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទនាមហាបាទ

Fig 9 Inscription no 1, face 4, eye-copy, with Suvannabhūmi highlighted (line 20–21). After Terwiel, *The Ram Khamhaeng Inscription*, p. 69.

The Wat Song Khob 1 inscription

A gold foil inscription dated BE 1951 (1408 CE) also refers to Sūbarṇabhūmī สุพรรณภูมิ, here as a *muang* เมือง. The rectangular foil, measuring 4.3 x 23.3 cm, was found in a *chedi* (*stupa*) at Wat Song Khob, Muang District, Chainat Province วัดสองคอบ, อำเภอเมือง จังหวัดชัยนาท in October, BE 2494 (CE 1951). The epigraph is engraved in the Thai language in the Khom Ayuthaya script อักษรขอมอยุธยา, with 9 lines on the recto and 6 lines on the verso.¹⁸ It relates the merit performed by Khun Phetayasan (Khun Bejñasār ขุนเพชรสาร), the ruler of Chainat (Krung Chaiyasathānanām กรุงไชยสถานนาม), at three important cities, each of which had a reliquary shrine (*phra siratanamahādhātu* พระศรีรัตนมหาธาตุ) at the centre of the city: Srī-Ayodhayā, Nagara Phrarām (Lopburi), and Sūbarṇabhūmī ศรี-อโยธยานครพระราม และ สุพรรณภูมิ.¹⁹ The latter is mentioned a second time as Sri-sūbarṇabhūmī ศรี-สุพรรณภูมิ.²⁰ (figs. 10, 11, and 12)

Suphanburi as Suvaṇṇabhūmi figures prominently in the *Jinakālamālīnī* in the story of the Sīhala Bud-

dha (*sīhalapaṭimāya āgamanakāla*), which is set in a network of Thai city states that includes Sukhothai, Chainat, Ayodhya, and Kamphaengphet กำแพงเพชร.²¹ These events lead on to the account of a group of twenty-five senior monks from Nabbi-sipura, plus eight from Kambojaratṭha, joined by six from Rammana, that is, thirty-nine *mahātheras*, going to train in Sri Lanka where they took ordination in 1424 at Kalyāṇī.

The two inscriptions show that, for the Thai in the Sukhothai–Ayuthaya period, Suvaṇṇabhūmi was located in the area of ancient U Thong อุทอง, one of the main centres of the culture that we call Dvāravatī. The name U Thong means ‘cradle of gold’.

Prasert and Griswold note:²²

Sūbarṇabhūmī is Subarṇapurī (Supānburi), whose exact location in the late 13th century is not known, though it was probably not far away from the present city of Subarṇapurī, founded in the 15th. The place now called Û Tòng had been abandoned in the 11th.

18 It is number ChaN 13 (ชน 13), published as Inscription no. 48 in *Prachum Silachareuk* Part 3 (ประชุมศิลาจารึก ภาค 3), no. 44//2499; *Chareuk nai prathet Thai*, Vol.5, National Library, The Fine Arts Department, Bangkok, 2529 [1986], pp. 77–84, read by Cham Thongkhamwan (จารึกในประเทศไทย เล่ม ๕); ‘Charuek lanthong Wat Song Khob 1’ (จารึกลานทองวัดสองคอบ 1); in Santi Pakdeekham, *Prawatisat Ayutthaya chak chareuk: Chareuk samai Ayutthaya*, Bangkok, Samakhom Prawatisat nai Phra Ratchupatham, 2561 [2018] (ธานี ถักดีคำ, ประวัติศาสตร์อยุธยาจากจารึก: จารึกสมัยอยุธยา, กรุงเทพฯ: สมาคมประวัติศาสตร์ในพระราชูปถัมภ์, 2561), pp. 111–120. For the publication history, see p. 113.

19 Side 1, line 6.

20 Side 2, line 3.

21 *Jinakālamālī* (Pali, ed. Buddhadatta), p. 87 foll.; *Epochs of the Conqueror* (English tr.), pp. 123 foll. For references, see Hans Penth, *Jinakālamālī Index*, The Pali Text Society, Oxford/Silkworm Books, Chiang Mai, 1994, pp. 189–190.

22 *Epigraphic and Historical Studies*, p. 281, n. 130.



Fig 10 Wat Song Khob 1 inscription, recto. After *Chareuk nai prathet Thai*, vol. 5, p. 79.

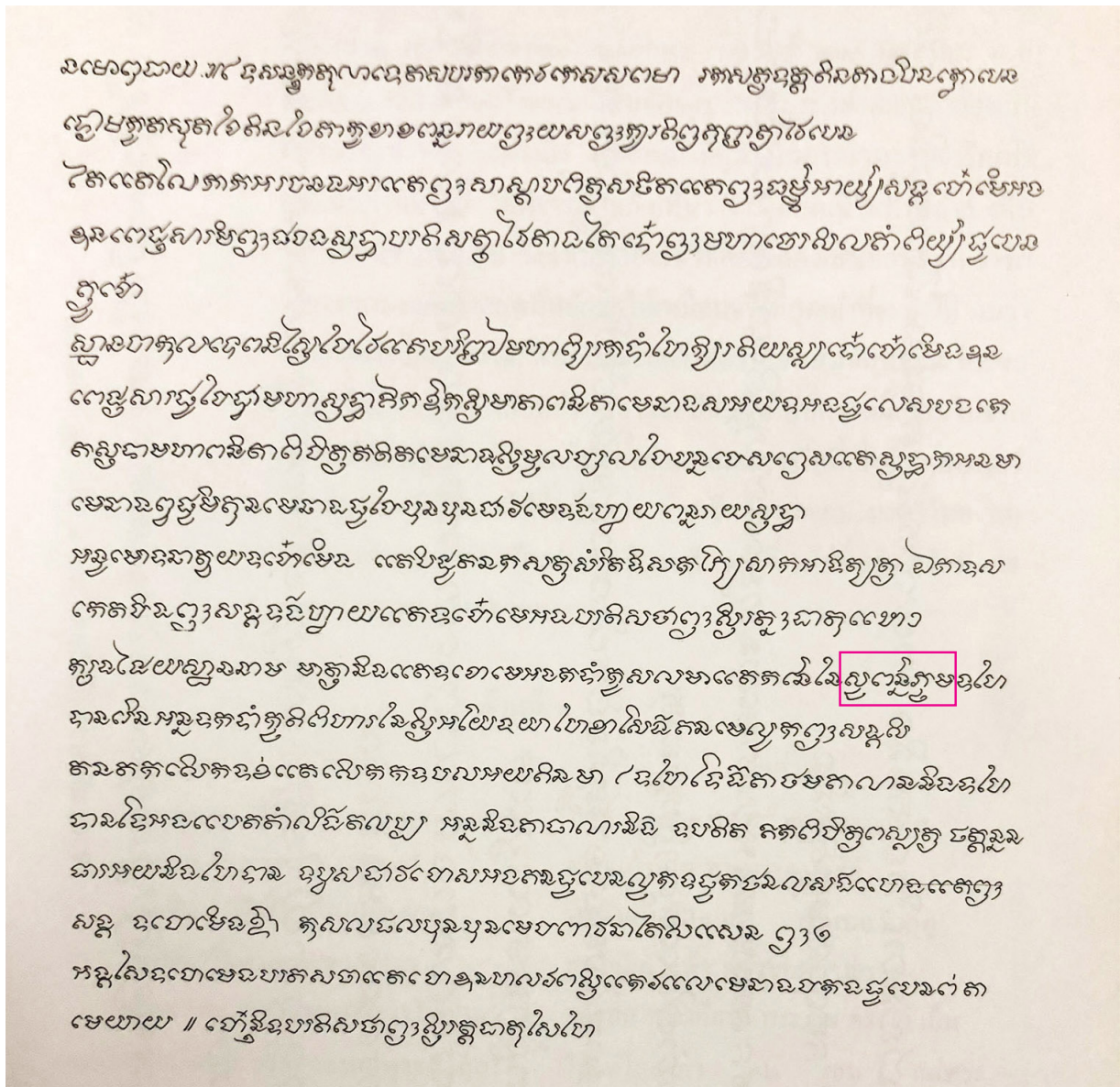


Fig 11 Wat Song Khop 1, face 1, inscription, recto. Eye-copy by Kongkaew Weeraprachak, from *Chareuk nai prathet Thai*, vol. 5, p. 80.

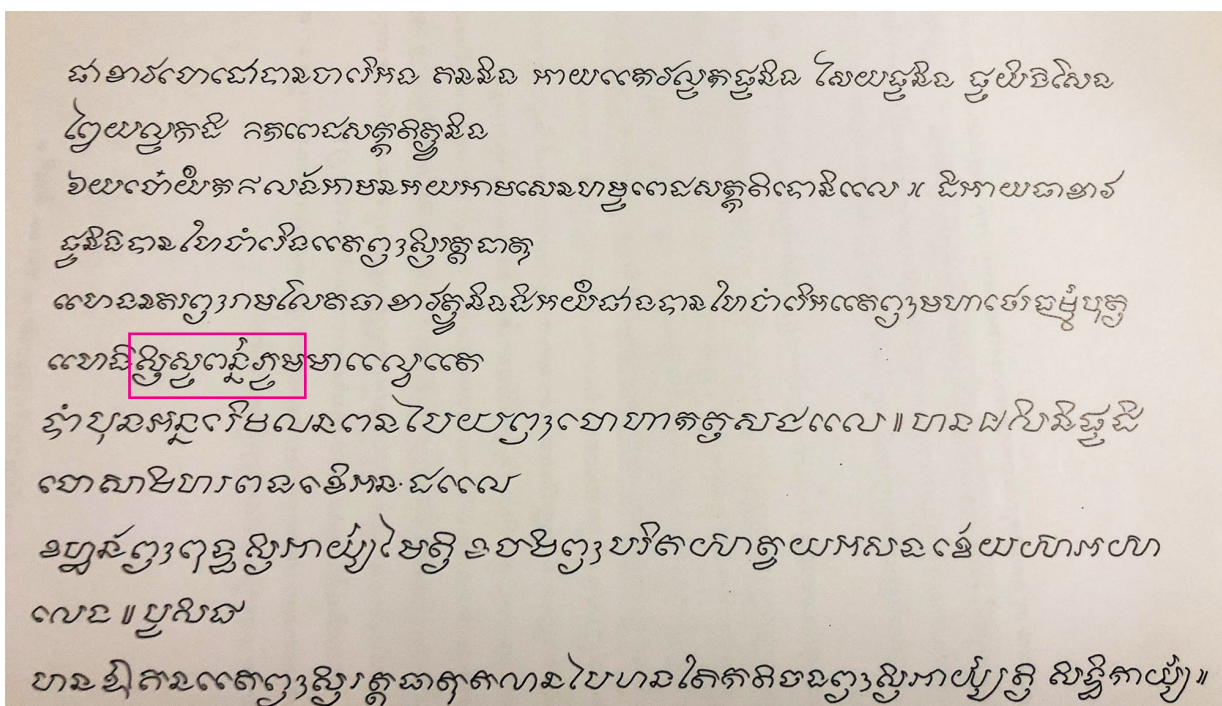


Fig 12 Wat Song Khop 1, face 2, inscription, recto. Eye-copy by Kongkaew Weeraprachak, from *Chareuk nai prathet Thai*, vol. 5, p. 80.

Suvaṇṇabhūmi in lower Burma: the Kalyāṇī inscriptions

By the first half of the fifteenth century, the Mon and the Thai saw central Southeast Asia as the Land of Gold. Towards the end of the fifteenth century, in 1476, the Mon king King Dhammaceti set up the Kalyāṇī Inscriptions in Mon and Pali near Pegu in lower Burma.²³ (figs. 13–15) At the outset, the first face invokes the Pali tradition that the monks Soṇa and Uttara were sent from the Mauryan capital Pāṭaliputra to Suvaṇṇabhūmi after the convocation-recitation held, according to the Pali chronicles of Sri Lanka, by King Dhammāsoka.²⁴ This seems to be a Theravādin tradition, not known by other Buddhist schools, and there is no archaeological or other evidence for the mission, for its historicity or for its success or failure. The inscriptions draw on the Pali *vaṃsas* for the authority of monastic lineages, and they interpret Suvaṇṇabhūmi as lower Burma, that is, Rāmaññadesa, the Mon country. The identification is also made in King Dhammaceti's Shwedagon Pagoda inscription erected in 1485. As far as I know, these are the oldest evidences for this localization of Suvaṇṇabhūmi in lower Burma, but I suspect that it is an ancient tradition rather than one invented by King Dhammaceti,²⁵ and that the tradition may have been shared by the Mon on both sides of today's border. The Dhammaceti inscriptions are the only Suvaṇṇabhūmi inscriptions that choose to reference the Pali *vaṃsa* tradition to frame the identification with the Golden Land. The other inscriptions presented here seem rather to draw on the general Indian and literary geography that identifies the Golden Land with Southeast Asia.

23 See Jason A. Carbine, 'Sāsanasuddhi: Simāsammuti: Comments on a Spatial Basis of the Buddha's Religion', in *How Theravāda Is Theravāda? Exploring Buddhist Identities*, Edited by Peter Skilling, Jason A. Carbine, Claudio Cicuzza, and Santi Pakdeekham, Chiang Mai, Silkworm Books, 2012, pp. 241–273; *ibid.*, 'How King Rāmādhīpati Handled His Boundary Case: *Simā*, *Sāsana*, and Buddhist Law', *Buddhism, Law & Society*, vol. 1 (2015–2016), pp. 105–164.

24 Taw Sein Ko, tr., *The Kalyāṇī Inscriptions Erected by King Dhammaceti at Pegu in 1476 A.D.*, Bangkok, Bangkok Times Press Limited, 1925, especially pp. 1–6.

25 This is the implication of Michael A. Aung-Twin, *The Mists of Rāmañña: The Legend That Was Lower Burma*, University of Hawai'i Press, Honolulu, 2005, pp. 67–78 *et passim*.

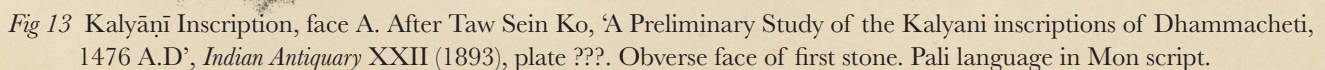
This supposition suggests a continuity from an earlier period, when Suvaṇṇabhūmi was alive in Indian literature, and the Thai period from the thirteenth century to the present, when Suphanburi is the name of a central province. Whether the name Suvaṇṇabhūmi invoked Sanskritic prestige and wealth cannot be said, and when the final *°bhūmi* became *°pura* or *°purī* needs further investigation. Is the transition from *°bhūmi* to *°pura/°purī* a conscious localization of the Golden Land? The neighbours Suphanburi and Lopburi were rival centres of power; Suphanburi played a significant role in the origins of Ayutthaya, but later fell into decline.²⁶ The Belgian Jacques de Coutre relates that in 1595 he went to the city of Sapampur, 'very large and in ruins'.²⁷ Sapampur might suggest Suvaṇṇapura (through Thai Suphanbura) rather than *°purī*, but linguistic distortions are so rife in early European transcriptions of toponyms that one cannot depend on a single record for any certainty.

In BE 2451 (1908) King Rama V (Chulalongkorn) travelled to the Makham Tao river, which becomes the Suphanburi river. He was informed that this was one of the former rivers of the Suvaṇṇabhūmi region.²⁸ In his entry for 20 October, he wrote, 'about 700 *sen* from the river there are earthen mounds alongside the road that are just like those at Pathom Chedi. Do they belong to the same period, or was [the capital] shifted from Pathom Chedi? In the region of this Suvaṇṇabhūmi, capitals were moved northwards, because the people of Malay country, that is, the people who lived in the Malay peninsula, came and caused trouble.' He wrote (p. 31) that the river was an ancient course of Suvaṇṇabhūmi,

26 For Suphanburi, see *The Tale of Khun Chang Khun Phaen, Siam's Great Folk Epic of Love and War*, translated and edited by Chris Baker and Pasuk Phongpaichit, illustrated by Muangsing Janchai, Silkworm Books, Chiang Mai, 2010, pp. 915–920.

27 *The Memoirs and Memorials of Jacques de Coutre: Security, Trade and Society in 16th- and 17th-century Southeast Asia*, edited with an Introduction by Peter Borschberg, translated by Roopanjali Roy, NUS Press Singapore, 2014, pp. 121–122 (see also p. 379).

28 *Phra ratchathathalekha ruang sadetpraphat lam-nam makham tao mua pho. so. 2451*, third printing, The Fine Arts Department, Bangkok, 2561, p. 31. I thank Santi Pakdeekham for pointing the passages out to me.



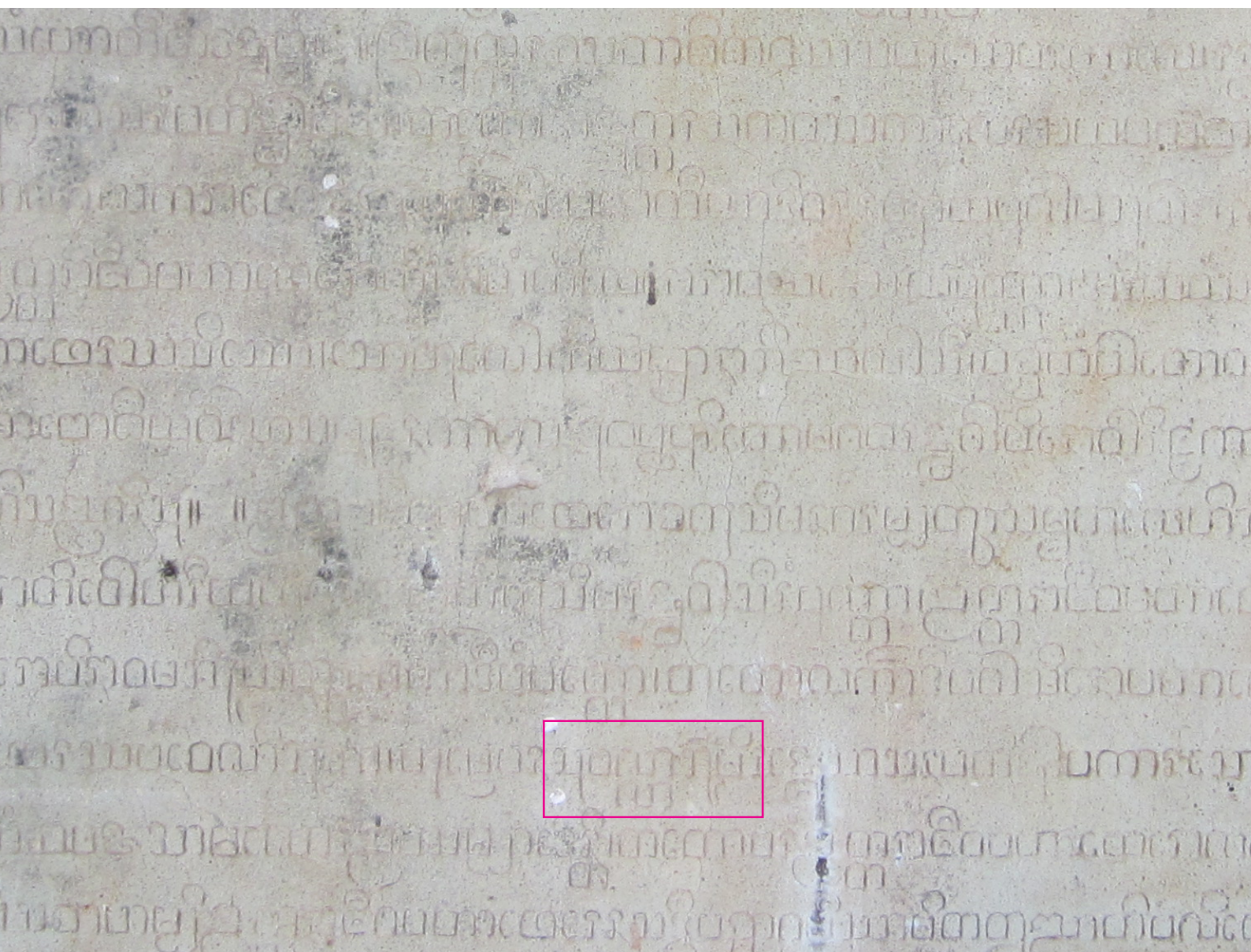


Fig 14

Fig 14 Kalyāṇī Inscription, face A. Highlight: Suvannabhūmi.
Pali language in Mon script. Photo courtesy Jason Carbine.

Fig 15 Taw Sein Ko, tr., *The Kalyāṇī Inscriptions Erected by Kīṅ Dhammaceti at Pegu in 1476 A.D.* First Thai publication of Kalyāṇī inscriptions, Bangkok, Bangkok Times Press Limited, 1925. Contains Pali in Thai script, Thai translation.

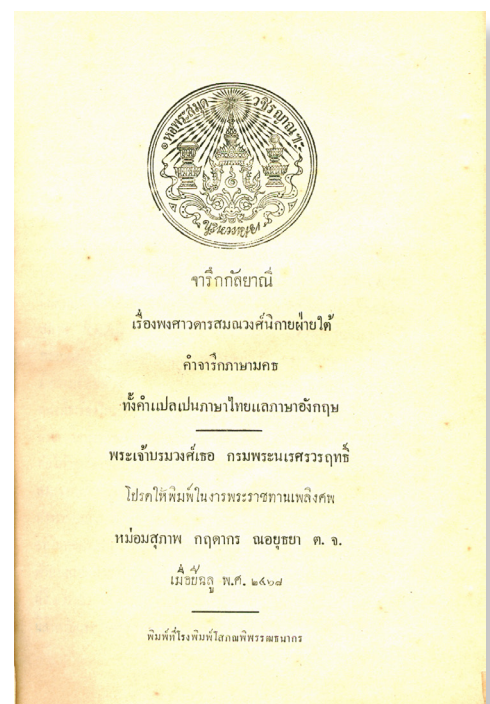


Fig 15

Suvarṇadvīpa in the mid-Thai–Malay peninsula: Dharmakīrti's *Durbodhāloka*

In the eleventh century CE, a learned monk named Dharmakīrti wrote a commentary on the *Ornament of Realization* (*Abhisamaya-ālaṃkāra*), one of the defining texts of the Buddhist curriculum in Pāla-period north India which remains a central text in Tibetan scholasticism to this day.²⁹ The *Ornament of Realization* is a complex and difficult text; Dharmakīrti's commentary bears the title *Durbodhāloka*, which means *Illumination of [points that are] difficult to understand*.³⁰ It is lost in the original Sanskrit but it survives in a Tibetan translation preserved in the Tibetan canon of translated Indian technical literature (Tanjur).

Where did Dharmakīrti write the *Durbodhāloka*? The concluding colophon (figs. 16–18), which was originally written in Sanskrit prose and verse, states that Dharmakīrti composed the *Durbodhāloka* in Vijaya, the glorious city (*pura, nagara*) of Suvarṇadvīpa,³¹ during the reign of Deva Śrī Cūḍāmaṇivarman, at the king's request.³²

29 This section draws on my earlier 'Geographies of Intertextuality: Buddhist Literature in Pre-modern Siam', *Aséanie - Sciences humaines en Asie du Sud-est* 19 (June 2007), pp. 91–112.

Note that the name Dharmakīrti was not uncommon, and there were several figures with the name among South and Southeast Asian intellectuals. The author of the *Durbodhāloka* is centuries later than the 'profound and rigorous philosopher of Indian Buddhism' (*circa* sixth-century, for whom see Tom Tillemans, 'Dharmakīrti', *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Spring 2017 Edition), Edward N. Zalta (ed.), URL = <<https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/spr2017/entries/dharmakīrti/>>. The two should not be conflated.

30 The full Sanskrit title of the work is *Abhisamayālaṃkāra-nāma-prajñāpāramitopadeśaśāstra-vṛtti-durbodhāloka-nāma-ṭīkā*.

31 The name of the city is made up of *śrī*, glorious + *vijaya*, victory. It can be interpreted, here and below, as a single unit, *śrīvijaya*, or with *śrī* as an adjective, qualifying the city of Vijaya. Vijaya as the name of a city (Vijayapura, for example) is well attested in Indian history. The question of the relationship between the 'glorious city' here and the famed 'empire of Śrīvijaya' cannot be easily solved. Taking account of the difficulties arising if the two names are taken to mean the same place, I interpret the city's name as Vijaya.

32 For an earlier study of the colophon, see Skilling, 'Dharmakīrti's *Durbodhāloka* and the Literature of Śrīvijaya'.

We know King Cūḍāmaṇivarman from other sources, including Chola inscriptions from South India (for example, the famous 'Leiden plates') and Chinese records.³³ It is therefore possible to date the composition of the *Durbodhāloka* to the late tenth century, or to before 1005. Given that the sources describe Cūḍāmaṇivarman as king of Kaṭāha (modern Kedah, at the northern head of the Straits of Malacca, in modern Malaysia), it is likely that the work was composed on the central Thai–Malay Peninsula—although such a conclusion is bound to be controversial. The colophon does not state explicitly that Dharmakīrti was a native of the Golden Land, but Tibetan sources consistently describe him as 'Dharmakīrti of Suvarṇadvīpa', and there is no reason that he should not have been, if not from Kedah itself, from Southeast Asia. He is always distinguished from other Indian teachers by the name 'the Suvarṇadvīpan'.

How did the *Durbodhāloka* come to be translated in Tibet? This was a time of active transregional exchange, with numerous monks and scholars from India and the region journeying to Tibet and beyond. In Tibet, the project of translation of Indian Buddhist works was revivifying after a period of disruption and instability. The translation of the *Durbodhāloka* is excellent: it was done by none other than one of the savants of the age, the renowned scholar monk Atiśa Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna (*circa* 982–1054) from southern Bengal (now Chittagong, Bangladesh)—which itself stands at the interstices of eastern India and Southeast Asia. Atiśa translated the text in Gugé, western Tibet, between 1042 and 1045 in collaboration with great translator, the *bhikṣu* Rinchen Zangpo (Rin chen bzang po, 958–1055).³⁴ Dharmakīrti's colophon is cast very much in the Indian style of the time. It reads:³⁵

33 For convenience see Coedès *Indianized States of Southeast Asia*, pp. 141–144. I do not necessarily accept all of Coedès' interpretations.

34 See Giuseppe Tucci, *Rin-chen-bzan-po and the Renaissance of Buddhism in Tibet around the Millennium*, New Delhi, Aditya Prakashan, 1988 (*Śāta-piṭaka Series, Indo-Asian Literatures*, Vol. 348) (first published in Italian, Roma: Reale Accademia d'Italia, Nov. 1932; English translation by Nancy Kipp Smith under the direction of Thomas J. Pritzker, edited by Lokesh Chandra).

35 *tshig don rtogs par dka' ba yi* || *de nyid snang ba zhes bya ba* || *bdag gis shyar 'di byas gyur pas* || *ma 'tshal dam pas bzod par mdzod* || *bsod nams 'di yis 'gro ba kun* || *shes rab pha rol phyin dngos shog* || *bdag kyang nam mkha'i dbyings 'dra bar* || *sems can don ni byed gyur cig* || *dpal ldan rnam rgyal nyams dga'i gnas* || *rgyal po dpal ldan gtsug nor bu* || *go chas chos kyi grags dpal la* || *gsol ba btab pas snang bar byas* ||.

I have composed this work entitled 'Illumination of Difficult Points'
If in doing so I have [written] anything
inappropriate
May the wise please forgive me.

By this merit (*punya*) may all beings
Realize the perfection of wisdom (*prajñāpāramitā*)
And may I act for the good (*artha*)
Of sentient beings equal to the element of
space (*ākāśadhātu*).

This Illumination (*āloka*) has been composed
By Dharmakīrtiśrī, at the request of the King,
The illustrious (*śrīmān*) Cūḍāmaṇivarman,
Of glorious Vijaya, the delightful abode.

Composed in Vijaya, the glorious city (*pura*,
nagara) of Suvarṇadvīpa, in the tenth regnal
year of Deva Śrī Cūḍāmaṇivarman, on the
eleventh day of the first month of spring

(*phālguna*), the *Durbodhāloka* is completed
(*samāpta*).³⁶

This is followed by a translators' colophon:³⁷

Translated, revised, and formalized by the
Indian preceptor (*upādhyāya*) Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna
and the great translator *bhikṣu* Rinchen bzang
po.

36 *gser gling gi dpal nram par rgyal ba'i grong du lha dpal gtsug gi
nor bu'i go cha rgyal po'i ring lo tshigs bcu pa las dpyid zla ra ba'i
tshes bcu gcig la mdzad pa | rtogs par dka' ba'i snang ba zhes bya ba
rdzogs so ||*.

37 *rgya gar gyi mkhan po dī paṃ ka ra shrī dznyā na dang | sgra
bsgyur gyi lo tsā ba chen po dge slong rin chen bzang pos bgyur cing
zhus te gnam la phab pa'o ||* Narthang and Peking editions
only add *'dis kyang bstan pa rin po che rgyas par byed nus par gyur
cig | shubham |*.



Fig 16

Woodblock of
Dharmakīrti
from Tibetan
Tanjur.



Fig 17

Woodblock of
Atiśa from
Tibetan
Tanjur.

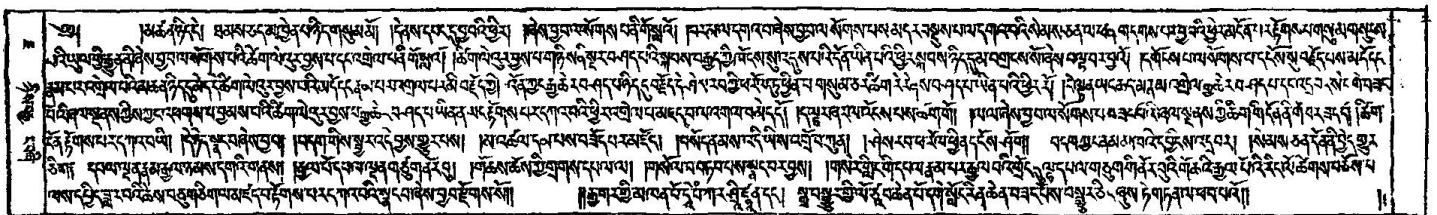


Fig 18 Colophon Dharmakīrti's *Durbodhāloka*. Xylograph, Tibetan language, U-chen script. Tibetan Tanjur: Derge, Cat. no. 3794, ja, folio 254a.

Suvarṇabhūmi in Sumatra: the Amoghapāśa inscription

An inscription from near Rambahan, West Sumatra, written in old Malay language in old Javanese script, records the setting up of a stone image of Ārya Amoghapāśa Lokeśvara in Śaka 1208 (CE 1286). The image (fig. 19) is massive, measuring 1.6 meters without the base (or 1.98 m with the base). Its iconography is complex: the standing image is surrounded by attendant figures, buddhas, and bodhisatvas. According to the inscription, it was brought ‘from *bhūmi* Jāva to Svarṇabhūmi’ to be set up in Dharmāśraya at the order of Mahārājādhirāja Śrī Kṛtanagara; it was accompanied on its trip of about 2000 kilometers by four high-ranking court officials. The record also mentions ‘*bhūmi* Malāyū’.³⁸ The inscription is engraved in neatly carved Kawi script on the large rectangular pedestal of the statue.

Here we find a local, perhaps both Javanese and Sumatran, identification of Sumatra with the Golden Land. In a way it complements the famous Nalanda copper-plate of Devapāladeva (figs. 20–22), in which king Devapāladeva at the request of Mahārāja Śrī Bālaputradeva, overlord of Suvarṇadvīpa (Suvarṇadvīpādhipati) granted five villages for the increase of merit (*puṇya*) and various requisites and supplies for the sangha of the four quarters.³⁹ The record also mentions the king of Yavabhūmi, ‘forehead ornament of the ancestral line of the Śailendras’ (*śailendrawaṃśatilako yavabhūmipālāḥ*). The Nalanda inscription dates to *circa* 860 and is thus over four hundred years earlier than the

Amoghapāśa inscription. Nonetheless, the two records are rare examples of mutual identifications of Suvarṇabhūmi on the two sides of the Indian Ocean and of connections between India and Suvarṇabhūmi.

But did the Indian Ocean have ‘two sides’ in this period? This seems doubtful. There was, rather, a religious and cultural continuum that, during the reign of the Pāla kings in eastern India, fostered networks of transregional relations in philosophy, art, ritual, and religious practice. The Thai-Malay peninsula and the ‘Eastern archipelago’—the islands of Indonesia—were in its orbit as was Tibet. Nalanda and other great Buddhist monasteries played crucial roles as training centres and disseminators of ideas and ideals.

This Pāla continuum is literally illustrated in several illuminated *Prajñāpāramitā* manuscripts of the period.⁴⁰ Miniature paintings depict important sacred images at sites across Nepal (Nepāla), north India (Magadha), Bengal (Puṇḍavardhana, Varendra, Candradvīpa), Sri Lanka (Sinhalaadvīpa), into Southeast Asia, including Yavadvīpa, Kalaśapura, and Kaṭāhadvīpa, all identified in Sanskrit labels. Especially interesting here is the ‘Lokanātha of Suvarṇapura in the glorious city of Vijaya’ (*suvarṇapure śrī vijayapure lokanātha*) (figs. 23–24). This caption immediately brings to mind ‘the glorious city (*pura*, *nagara*) of Vijaya of Suvarṇadvīpa’ of Dharmakīrti’s colophon. Can the two documents possibly refer to the same place in the peninsula? One question leads to another: we need to ask just what the Pāla miniatures were meant to represent, and how? These questions that can scarcely be answered since the original buildings and statues no longer exist. In one case, the miniature of Kṛṣṇagiri or Kanheri shows rocks, caves, and a stūpa set within a cave—it relates to the known terrain, the actual site. To what degree, if any, could this be the same for other miniatures? To what degree do they draw on reports and memories of pilgrimage?

38 For a transcription see L.-C. Damais, ‘Études d’épigraphie indonésienne.- IV. Discussion de la date des inscriptions’, *Bulletin de l’Ecole française d’Extrême-Orient*, 47 (1) (1955), pp. 99–101. Also N.J. Krom, ‘Een Sumatraansche inscriptie van koning Kṛtanagara’ *Verslagen en Mededeelingen der Koninklijke Akademie van Wetenschappen*, afd. Letterkunde, 5de reeks, 2, 1917, pp. 306–339 (not seen). For the image see, *Sumatra: Crossroads of Cultures*, edited by Francine Brinkgreve and Retno Sulistianingsih, KITLV Press, Leiden, 2009, pp. 89–90 and figs. 6.3, 6.4; Natasha Reichle, *Violence and Serenity: Late Buddhist Sculpture from Indonesia*, University of Hawai’i Press, Honolulu, 2007, pp. 120–132.

39 Hiranand Sastri, ‘The Nalanda Copper-plate of Devapāladeva’, *Epigraphia Indica* XVII (1923–24), pp. 310–327; Hiranand Sastri, *Nālandā and Its Epigraphic Material* (Memoirs of the Archaeological Survey of India no. 66), Delhi, 1942, pp. 92–102.

40 See A. Foucher, *Étude sur l’iconographie bouddhique de l’Inde d’après des documents nouveaux*, Ernest Leroux, Paris, 1900, ‘Catalogue’, pp. 189–214, and Jinah Kim, ‘Painted palm-leaf manuscripts and the Art of the Book in medieval South Asia,’ *Archives of Asian Art* 65.2 (2015), pp. 57–86. The Sanskrit names given in the following are taken from the manuscript.



Fig 19 Amoghapaśa, Museum Nasional Indonesia., inv. No. 6469. After John N. Miksic, *Icons of Art: The Collections of the National Museum of Indonesia*, BAB Publishing Indonesia, 2007, p. 100.

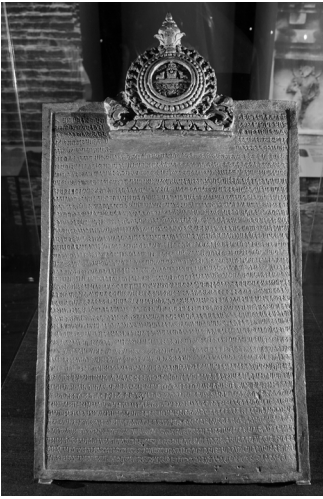


Fig 20 Devapāladeva copper-plate inscription, Nalanda. Recto. Nalanda Museum, Nalanda. Photo courtesy 'On the Nalanda Trail' exhibition, ACM, Singapore.

Fig 21 Devapāladeva copper-plate inscription, Nalanda: detail, recto.

Fig 22 Estampage of Devapāladeva inscription, Nalanda. After Sastri, 'The Nalanda Copper-plate of Devapāladeva', *Epigraphia Indica* XVII, plate facing p. 320.

Fig 20

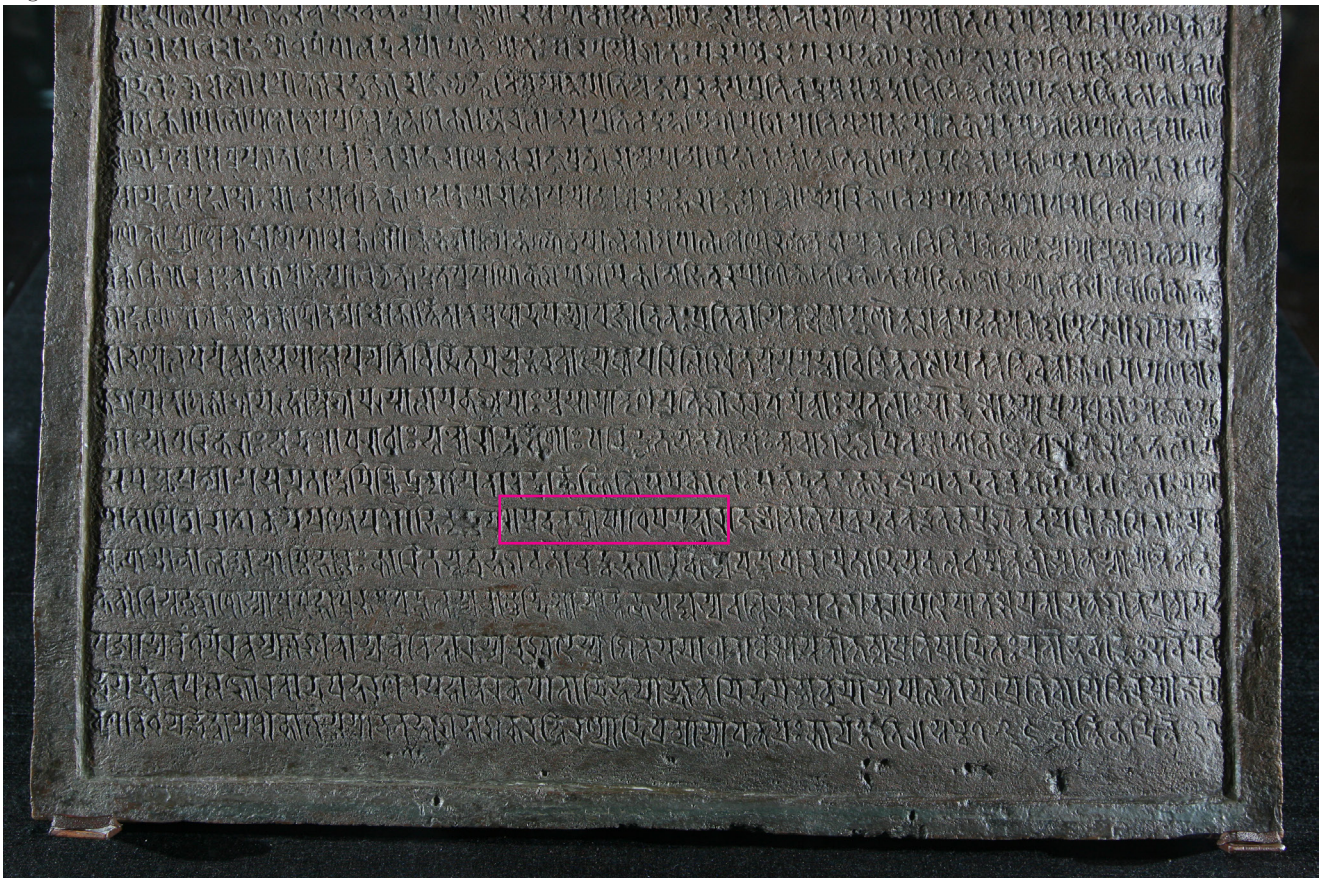


Fig 21

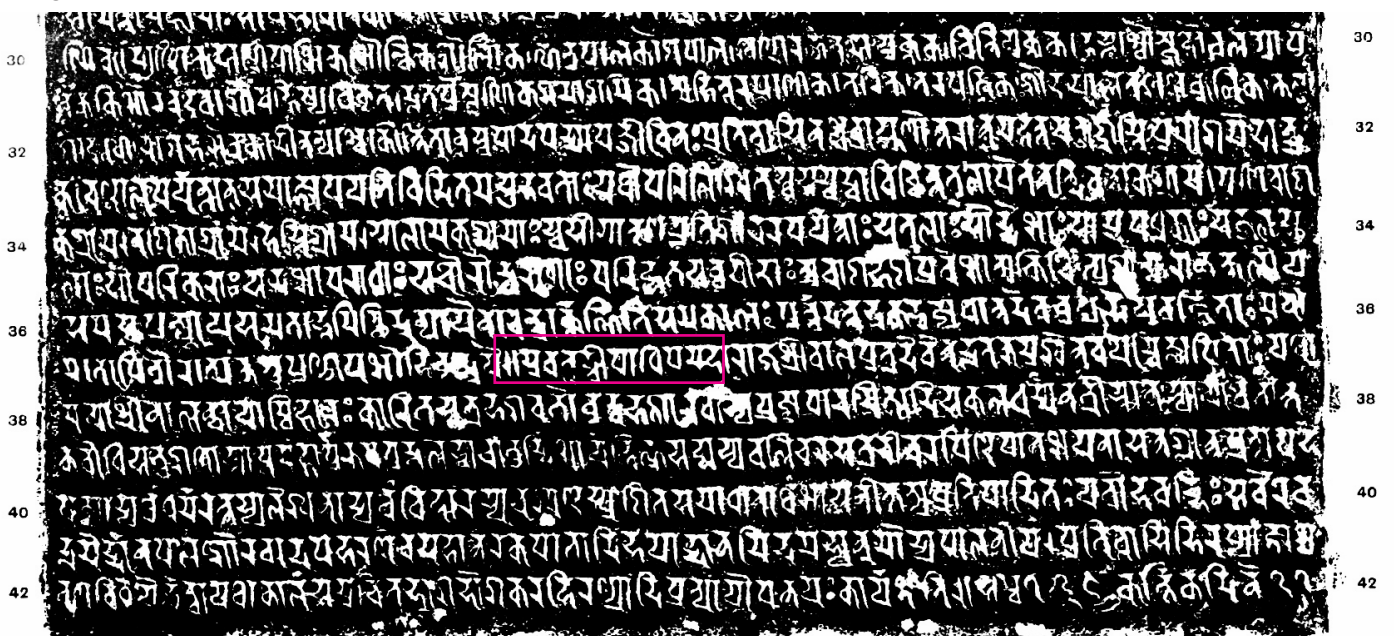


Fig 22



Fig 23

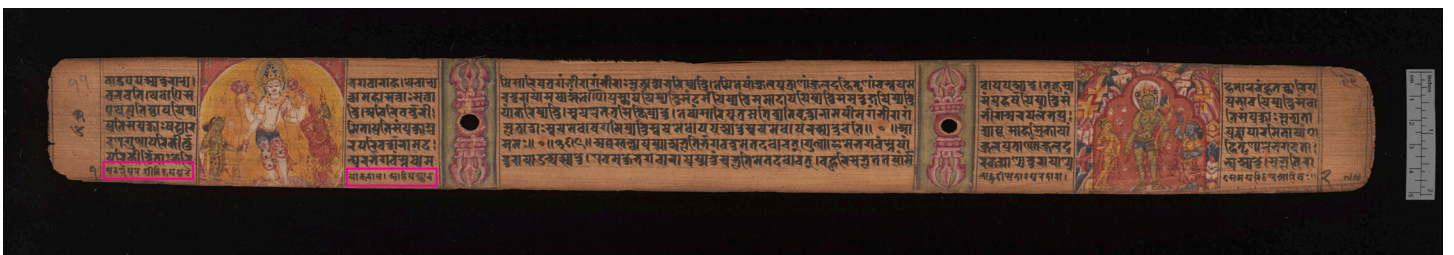


Fig 24

Figs 23,24 'Lokanātha of Suvarṇapura in the glorious city of Vijaya' (*suvarṇapure śrī vijayapure lokanātha*). Palm-leaf manuscript of the *Perfection of Wisdom in 8000 Lines*, Cambridge University.

सुवर्णभूमे श्रीविजयपुरे

suvarṇabhūme śrīvijayapure

लोकनाथ। अरिस्तहान।

lokanātha | āriṣasthāna⁴¹

⁴¹ The meaning of *āriṣasthāna*, which occurs with variants in the 'captions' of many of the miniatures, has not been satisfactorily explained.

It might seem rash to ask whether the celebrated Padmapāṇi from Wat Wiang, Chaiya (fig. 25), could have been one of the famous images of the Pāla period. The large image is skillfully crafted from bronze with silver inlay. But it is badly mutilated: the arms are broken off and the lower body and the legs are missing. Only the upper half survives, and this raises two important questions: was the image standing or sitting, and how many arms did it have? The surviving statue measures 63 cm from the waist to the top of the head. It is generally held to have been standing, although this cannot be said with absolute certainty—seated images with a torso turned in the same way were also produced in the peninsula. The statue *appears* to have two arms against the four of the miniature. This too is not certain. The right arm is broken at the shoulder, and the break seems almost too large for a single arm. We can see from other four-armed images that there were several ways to represent multiple arms: sometimes the arms begin at the shoulder, sometimes from the elbow, and so on. Therefore, whether the image was standing or sitting, and how many arms it had are uncertain. Whether or not it was a standing, four-armed image, the jewellery, the long strands of hair that fall down over the shoulders, the graceful *tribhaṅga*, all bear a resemblance to the miniature, and district Chaiya is an area redolent with memories of Śrīvijaya—perhaps not Ferrand’s ‘empire sumatranais’ or Coëdès’s ‘royaume de Çrīvijaya’, but the glorious City of Victory evoked in the Wiangsa inscription. Certainly we cannot expect photographic realism, but we can posit a relation between the Chaiya image and the miniature. It would go too far to suggest that the miniature depicts the Chaiya image, however, and it is more reasonable to consider the resemblance to be generic, and to regard the two images as expressions of the aesthetic and spiritual ideals of the age.

There are similar clusters of place names in Tibetan sources.⁴² In his *History of Buddhism*, the Tibetan master Bu ston rin chen grub (1290–1364) lists Rugma, Ramma, Tāmradvīpa, Siṅhaladvīpa, Priyaṅgudvīpa, Yamunādvīpa, Suvarṇadvīpa, and Candradvīpa as places where the teaching was expounded and the scriptures of the three vehicles, either complete or incomplete, have been preserved.⁴³ In his *History of Buddhism*, Tāranātha

42 That the authors may be drawing on a common source (and this is a complex question that needs further research) does not lessen the significance of the lists insofar as they point to a consciously shared geographical vision.

43 E. Obermiller, tr., *History of Buddhism (Chos-hbyung)* by Bu-ston, II. Part, *The History of Buddhism in India and Tibet*, Heidelberg, 1932, p. 171. See also Lisa Stein and Ngawang Zangpo, tr., *Butön’s History of Buddhism in India and Its Spread to Tibet: A Treasury of Priceless Scripture*, Boston & London,



Fig 25 Padmapāṇi from
Wat Wiang, Chaiya

(1575–1634) lists Siṅgaladvīpa, Yavadvīpa, Tāmradvīpa, Suvarṇadvīpa, Dhanaśrīdvīpa, and Pa yi gu,⁴⁴ and he refers to some of these sites more than once in his other works. The remarkable young scholar had close contacts with Indian yogis in central Tibet.

Earlier in this century, Sheldon Pollock writes:⁴⁵

[I]n the first millennium it makes hardly more sense to distinguish between South and Southeast Asia than between north India and south India, despite what present-day area

Snow Lion, 2013, p. 266. I follow the Tibetan text in Rdo rje rgyal po, ed., *Bu ston chos 'byung*, Krung go bod kyi shes rig dpe skrun khang, 1988, p. 172.19 foll. *rug ma dang | ram ma dang | zangs gling dang | siṅga la'i gling dang | phri yang ku'i gling dang | ya mu na'i gling dang | gser gling dang | zla ba'i gling dang | ma kha dang | kha sha dang* |. The identification of all of the places is not clear: Priyaṅgudvīpa may be the same as Pa yi gu, that is, the Mon centre of Pegu in lower Burma.

44 Tibetan after Antonius Schiefner, ed., *Tāranāthae de doctrinae buddhicae in india propagatione narratio. Contextum tibeticum e codicibus petropolitanis*, p. 200.16. *siṅga la'i gling dang nas gling dang | zangs gling dang | gser gling dang | dhanaśrī gling dang | pa yi gu zhes bya ba'i gling phran de dag rams*. Translations in Debiprasad Chattopadhyaya, ed., *Tāranātha's History of Buddhism in India*, translated from the Tibetan by Lama Chimpa and Alaka Chattopadhyaya, KP Bagchi and Company, Calcutta, 1980, p. 332; Anton Schiefner, *Tāranātha's Geschichte des Buddhismus in Indien aus dem tibetischen uebersetzt*, St. Petersburg, 1869, pp. 263–264. See further commentary and identifications in Nihar-Ranjan Ray, *Sanskrit Buddhism in Burma*, H.J. Paris, Amsterdam, 1936, pp. 72–87.

45 Sheldon Pollock, *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture, and Power in Premodern India*, Berkeley, University of California Press, 2006, p. 16.

studies may tell us. Everywhere similar processes of cosmopolitan transculturation were under way, with the source and target of change always shifting, since there was no single point of production for cosmopolitan culture. Yet just as Southeast Asia was included in the circulatory space of the cosmopolitan order, so it came to be included in its conceptual space thanks to the transportability, so to speak, of that space. In their own geographic imagination the imperial polities of Southeast Asia—Angkor around 1000 is exemplary here—made themselves part of the cosmopolitan order by a wholesale appropriation of its toponymy. With Mount Meru and the Gaṅgā River locatable everywhere, there was no spatial center from which one could be excluded: the Sanskrit cosmopolis was wherever home was. There is nothing in the least mystical about this replicability; it is a function of a different, plural, premodern logic of space.

Although Pollock's cosmopolitanist ardour might be a bit over the top, he makes several decidedly important points. I do not sense that there are gaps or borders in the Pāla continuum; there is a sense of participation rather than of distance. Suvarṇabhūmi participated in the circulatory and conceptual spaces of the cosmopolitan order. What Pollock fails to emphasize is that important energies in the cosmopolitan transculturations of Asia and Southeast Asia were generated by the extensive and dynamic Buddhist networks.

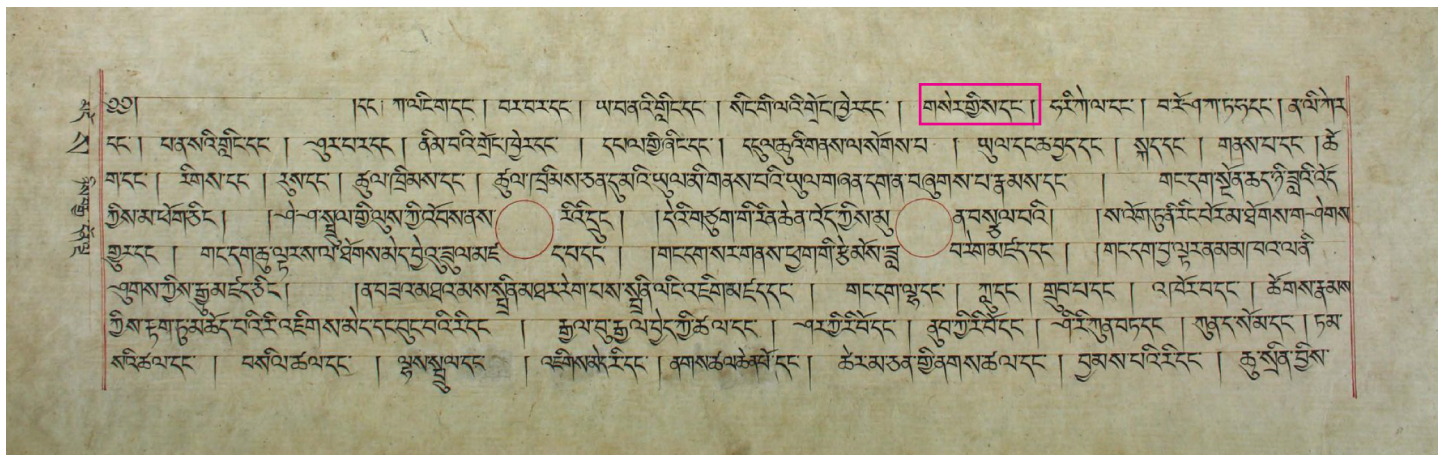


fig. 26 'Invitation of Senious Monks', Tibetan text, U-med script, Them Spangs ma Kanjur, Mdo, sa, 275a, National Library of Mongolia, Ulan Bator.

Suvarṇabhūmi as Southeast Asia

I have presented several Suvarṇabhūmis – in central Thailand, lower Burma, the mid Thai-Malay peninsula, and Sumatra. None of them is newly discovered, and they have been discussed before in the modern intellectual search for the Land of Gold. But what do they tell us? In my estimate, they teach us that Suvarṇabhūmi is a cultural code, a cultural package that was attractive to at least some of the courts of Southeast Asia. Rulers and court intellectuals *chose* to situate themselves in Suvarṇabhūmi and they *chose* to participate in its conceptual identity.

The identification of sites, the matching of texts and toponyms with the ‘known’ landscape, is not easy and is often contentious. For example, many of us assume that the Laṅkā of the Rāmāyaṇa is the island that we know today as Sri Lanka. But historians put forward several other hypotheses, for various reasons, one being that at the time of the formation and writing of the Epic, the island was not known as Laṅkā, but as Tāmrāparṇī, Sīhaladvīpa, or other names. Some would locate Laṅkā in the Vindhya mountains, others in the lower Mahanadi valley in Odisha. Romila Thapar writes, ‘When historians speak of the historicity of person, place or event, they require evidence—singular or plural—that proves the existence of any of these and this evidence is based on data relating to space and time. The two important spaces in the Valmiki *Ramayana* are Ayodhya and Lanka. The location of both is uncertain.’ She notes further that a ‘co-relation can only be clinched when inscribed objects are found that were common to both textual and archaeological sources’.⁴⁶ I find it odd that no one brings the Buddhist evidence into the discussion: the Pali chronicles written in Sri Lanka itself, or the *Laṅkāvatāra-sūtra* ([*The Buddha’s*] *Visit to Laṅkā*), which opens with the Buddha teaching the Dharma at the citadel of Rāvaṇa on Mt. Malaya.⁴⁷ But this is a complicated

question, which I reserve for another occasion.

The primary sources discussed here show that Suvarṇabhūmi did exist historically as a point of reference for Southeast Asia courts, but they do not ‘clinch’ any of the sites as an exclusive or ‘national’ Land of Gold. There is nothing new in this; the idea has been proposed long ago.

Let us return to Tibet, where a text with the Sanskrit title *Sthaviropāṇimantrana* or ‘Invitation of Senior Monks’ lists a string of place-names (fig. 12).⁴⁸

Kalinga, Barba, Yavana’i gling (Yabana-dvīpa but the reading Nas gling is better, Yava-dvīpa, with Narthang), Sing ga la’i gling (Siṃhala-dvīpa), Kalaśa’i grong khyer (Kalaśa-nagara), Gser gyi sa (Suvarṇa-bhūmi), Harikela (Harikela, Bengal), Ba ro sha ka ta ha (Parośa and Kaṭāha?), Nalikela (Nārikela), Pa na sa’i gling (Kambu-dvīpa?), Śu sa ra (?) and Nimba’i grong khyer (Nimba-nagara?) Dpal gyi zhing (Śrīkṣetra), Dngul chu’i gnas (Pārada-sthān?), and so on, and those other inhabited countries with peoples of various dress, languages, localities and practices, lineages, family lines; virtuous and pious, dwelling in various countries, these other lands inhabited by human beings...

In this perspective, Suvarṇabhūmi was one of the many regions of Southeast Asia recognized in the Indian knowledge system. The Golden Land was not a state, a country, or a city that can be pinpointed on a Google map. We have seen it as a self-identification for areas of Lower Burma, Thailand, the Malay peninsula, and as far south as Sumatra. We do not have any social documents—diaries or letters, memoirs or maps—to guide us, but despite this the default identification of Suvarṇadvīpa seems

48 Derge Tanjur, Cat. no. 4199, *Spring yig, nge*, translated circa 800 CE by Jinamitra and Ye shes sde. I follow the *Dpe bsdur ma* edition, vol. 96, p. 1014.2–9: *ka ling ga dang | barba dang | ya ba na’i gling* (var. *nas gling*) *dang | sing ga la’i gling dang | ka la śa’i grong khyer dang | gser gyi sa dang | ha ri ke la* (var. *ha ri ke ra*) *dang | ba ro sha ka ta ha dang | na ri ke la dang | pa na sa’i gling dang | śu sa ra dang | nimba’i grong khyer dang | dpal gyi zhing dang | dngul chu’i gnas la sogs pa yul dang | cha byad dang | skad dang | gnas pa dang | cho ga dang | rigs dang | rus dang | tshul khrims dang | tshul khrims can du du ma’i yul | mi gnas pa’i yul gzhan dag na bzhuḡs pa rnam* *dang | ...* See the translation as given in F.W. Thomas, *Tibetan Literary Texts and Documents concerning Chinese Turkestan*, Part I: *Literary Texts*, The Royal Asiatic Society, London, 1935, p. 262.

46 Romila Thapar, *The Past as Present: Forging Contemporary Identities Through History*, Aleph, New Delhi, 2014, pp. 234, 237.

47 For Mt. Malaya, see Malalasekera, *Dictionary of Pali Proper Names*, vol. II, pp. 448–449.

in some circles to have become Sumatra, especially Palembang.⁴⁹ In modern translations of the story of Atiśa's eleventh-century voyage to Suvarṇadvīpa to study under the master Dharmakīrti, Suvarṇadvīpa *automatically* becomes Sumatra. Dharmakīrti became known in Tibet as the 'Master from Suvarṇadvīpa' (Tib. Gser gling pa), but none of the narratives give any precisions as to where this Suvarṇadvīpa was. 'Palembang' or 'Jambi' or 'Sumatra' do not come from any of the source texts. The source texts mention only Gser gling, 'golden island': the modern toponyms are the elaborations of modern researchers.

In one account of Atiśa's voyage, a wrathful Maheśvara creates havoc and orders Atiśa not to go to Zangs gling, that is to say, Tāmradvīpa, which here might be South India, Sri Lanka, or even Tāmbraliṅga, Nakhon Sri Thammarat in South Thailand. Modern writings take a shortcut and write that Atiśa went to Palembang, or Sumatra, without pausing to clarify that this is an interpretation, a hypothesis. I find it methodologically inappropriate to close a question when it is has not yet been properly posed and has certainly not yet been solved. Is it not better to recognise what we don't know, and to investigate further? We know so little. The merchants Trapuṣa and Bhallika received hair relics from the newly awakened Śākyamuni, but we do not know where they came from or where they went. The monks Sona and Uttara were sent to Suvarṇabhūmi from Pāṭaliputta in the third century BCE, but we do not know where this was, or whether they ever reached the place. We do not know where the mariners and merchants in the oceans of Indian stories were shipwrecked. We do not know where the learned master Dharmakīrti lived and taught, or where Atiśa studied under him. Is it the historian's goal to counterfeit certitude, to wave a wand and transform uncertainties into certainties? To settle a

49 See for example Hubert Decleer, 'Atiśa's Journey to Sumatra', in Donald S. Lopez, Jr., ed., *Buddhism in Practice*, Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1995, pp. 532–540. For the Tibetan, I have consulted *rgyal ba'i 'byung gnas. 'jo bo gser gling du byon pa'i rnam thar/*.' *jo bo rje dpal ldan a ti sha'i rnam thar bka' gdams pha chos*. TBRC W00KG09688. zi ling /: mtsho sngon mi rigs dpe skrun khang /, 1994 : 37–51, retrieved from <http://tbr.org/link?RID=O2DB96991> |.

question is to close it: to stop asking, to stop searching, and to stop looking for further evidence. I believe that we should be true to the text and the evidence, and that we need to bracket, to clearly distinguish, the *text* from our *interpretation*. The Suvarṇabhūmi that we *can* approach lives in memory and in imagination, and in our attempts to understand the past and to locate our own cultural roots. There is no need to forge a pedigree.

Suvarṇabhūmi was a land where Sanskrit and Buddhist cultures flourished; it has bequeathed us elegant Sanskrit inscriptions and iconographic masterpieces in metal and stone. Suvarṇabhūmi was an open and commodious land, generous and tolerant. It had its own spiritualities and cultures, which were ready to welcome Brahmanism and Buddhism, then Chinese religions, Christianity and Islam, and, finally, the currents of modern science and thought. The variety of local traditions blended with Sanskritic values to create a marvelous heritage that is shared today by the ASEAN countries. Suvarṇabhūmi was a place of passage, a place of cultural exchange, of trade and of business. It is in this sense that Suvarṇabhūmi is appropriate as the name of a major airport in the heart of mainland Southeast Asia. We do not know what the bards and fabulists meant when they wrote of Suvarṇadvīpa and Suvarṇabhūmi, but today the heart of the Golden Land still beats, and animates a pageant of unique cultural opportunities that enrich human experience.

Paul Wheatley concluded:⁵⁰

whatever the name signified to those who braved the perils of the ocean, it is more than doubtful if the Indians of the Classical period in general entertained any conception of Suvarṇadvīpa more precise than that of a beckoning eldorado beyond the ocean.

Suvarṇabhūmi evokes cooperation over competition, culture over commerce, transregional exchange over narrow nationalism. Suvarṇabhūmi was an idea and an ideal. This does not detract from its place in history: it enhances it.

50 Wheatley, *Nāgara and Commandery*, p. 267 (cited in Skilling, 'Dharmakīrti's Durbodhāloka', p. 188).

I cannot announce that Suvarṇabhūmi has been found, and I do not say that it has ever been lost. I wonder, rather, whether the quest has not been ill directed, looking high and low for a definitive Suvarṇabhūmi, rather than breathing the air of the Golden Land. In any case, new evidence will inevitably surface, like the Kompong Speu inscription from Cambodia, and pose new questions and provoke fresh thought. This discovery of the inscription does not clinch that ‘Cambodia was home to Asia’s ancient “Land of Gold”’, but it adds to our knowledge—that Cambodia shared in the Indic or regional geography. As far as I know, old Khmer records, from the beginning up to the Angkor and post-Angkor periods, do not identify with or evoke the Land of Gold, despite the wealth of epigraphic data.